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HOSPITALITY AND TOURISM | REVIEW ARTICLE

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Conversational AI in hospitality and tourism: a bibliometric–systematic review

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ABSTRACT

This study examines how conversational artificial intelligence (chatbots, virtual assistants, and large language model–based agents) shapes the customer journeys of travellers, guests, and visitors in hospitality and tourism, including hotel, online travel agency, and airline services. We consolidate dispersed findings into an integrated account that links conversational design levers, psychological mechanisms, outcomes, and contextual boundaries. Using a protocolised bibliometric–systematic review of Scopus (search window 2010–2025; final $n = 71$ journal articles), we apply transparent eligibility criteria, quality appraisal, structured coding, and bibliometric mapping across booking, concierge/guest service, recommendation/personalisation, and service recovery touchpoints. Evidence indicates that response speed, message concision, empathic style, anthropomorphism, disclosure/explanation practices, visual/emoji enrichment, privacy-by-design features, and hybrid human handoff influence trust, perceived competence, reduced expectancy violation, perceived control, inspiration, and rapport. These mechanisms are associated with adoption and continuance, purchase and recommendation, satisfaction and loyalty, recovery effectiveness, and willingness to disclose data, with effects moderated by task complexity, failure severity, user traits, setting, and culture/digital literacy. From a practical perspective, this synthesis also provides guidance for hospitality and tourism practitioners on aligning large language model (LLM) capabilities with customer-journey touchpoints, calibrating response time and message concision to task and social context, implementing privacy-preserving personalisation, and maintaining human involvement in high-stakes or emotionally sensitive interactions.

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1. Introduction

Conversational AI now shapes many steps in the hotel and travel journey, including searching for ideas, planning, booking, in-stay help, and problem handling. Hotels have moved from simple rule-based tools to context-aware assistants that sit in daily work routines and influence guest experience, staff tasks, and management decisions, as shown in studies from 2024 and 2025 (Prasanna et al., 2025; Xu & Chen, 2025). Recent reviews report that large models such as ChatGPT support many languages, offer stronger personalisation, and handle text, images, and voice in one exchange, but they also note risks tied to accuracy, fairness, job impact, and responsible use (Altinay et al., 2025; Carvalho & Ivanov, 2024; Saleh, 2025). Tourism is a tough field for these tools because information shifts fast, guests expect warm and reliable help, and contact points span digital and physical spaces used by diverse users. In this paper, the term "travel customer" refers to travellers, guests, and visitors who use tourism and hospitality services.

A growing empirical base associates specific conversational-design choices with behavioural and attitudinal outcomes. Multi-study experiments and field surveys suggest that response speed, message

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concision, empathy signalling, anthropomorphism, disclosure/explanation practices, and visual/emoji cues are linked to decision comfort, satisfaction, trust, purchase/recommendation intentions, and continuance (Hernandez-Bocanegra & Ziegler, 2023; Kim et al., 2025a, 2025b; Kumar, 2025; Park et al., 2025; Yu et al., 2025; Zhang et al., 2024). Adoption-focused studies typically foreground performance expectancy and perceived enjoyment/utility, while revealing boundary conditions tied to technology anxiety, personal innovativeness, digital literacy, and culture (Foroughi et al., 2025; Pham, 2025a, 2025b; Vena-Oya et al., 2024). Prototype deployments extend scope to retrieval-augmented destination assistants (RAG) and embodied concierge robots, strengthening external validity for journey-wide design claims (Cruz et al., 2025; Klaus, 2025; Yamazaki et al., 2023).

Several issues still limit progress in both theory and practice. Past reviews on AI in hospitality and tourism mainly classify tools, track adoption, or list common uses (e.g. Li et al., 2021; Benaddi et al., 2024; Tuo et al., 2025). They rarely link design choices in conversational systems with the psychological factors that shape guest behaviour or with the context that changes across each step of the customer journey. Most of these studies also came before the rise of large multimodal models. As a result, they do not show how generative and multimodal AI change core elements of hospitality interactions, such as trust, empathy, and control.

Second, the rise of large models creates new risks for travel decisions. Hallucinated details and unclear sources can reduce perceived accuracy and lower interest in a visit. Early or poorly framed disclosure of an AI agent can also weaken empathy during service recovery (Fan et al., 2024; Kim et al., 2025a, 2025b). These risks create a design dilemma for practitioners. They want broad automation for speed and coverage, but they must avoid harm to trust, service quality, or fairness. To resolve this tension, we need a clear and well-reviewed synthesis that links design choices to the psychological forces that drive user responses and that sets out the conditions under which these links hold. This study extends earlier reviews by pairing bibliometric mapping with a mechanism-based synthesis to show how conversational design shapes behaviour and attitudes in hospitality and tourism across different contexts.

Candidate solutions appear across many separate lines of work. User-experience studies show that response-time targets should match task complexity and the effort people expect from an AI. They also show that message length and style should fit the social setting and the distance between the user and the service (Kim et al., 2025a, 2025b; Yu et al., 2025). Research on transparency and governance advises context-sensitive disclosure, clear "why" and "how" explanations for suggestions, and labels for synthetic content when it can distort social proof (Carvalho & Ivanov, 2024; Hernandez-Bocanegra & Ziegler, 2023; Mladenović et al., 2024). In high-stakes failures, evidence supports a sequence that starts with an apology or acknowledgement before giving factual fixes. It also supports the use of defaults that lower emotional effort and help users continue without feeling pressured (Wang et al., 2024; Zaki & Al-Romeedy, 2024). These ideas are useful but still scattered. This gap shows the need for a full journey-level review built on strong methods. In response, this study brings together existing findings to outline stable mechanisms across touchpoints and to offer design principles that are grounded in theory and useful in practice for responsible conversational AI in hospitality and tourism.

Mechanisms reported in the literature help operationalise such prescriptions. Empathic expression and warmth/competence cues are associated with lower expectancy violation and higher satisfaction in recommendation contexts; anthropomorphic design can elicit affect that cascades to brand love and recommendation intention in online travel agencies; visual/emoji enrichment may heighten perceived responsiveness and social playfulness in concierge interactions (Kumar, 2025; Park et al., 2025; Zhang et al., 2024). Conversely, LLM accuracy lapses can lower perceived credibility and behavioural intention, with effects moderated by error prominence and type (Cruz et al., 2025; Kim et al., 2025a, 2025b). Privacy-by-design also appears consequential: latent-profile analyses identify guest segments more willing to disclose personal information (or pay) for personalised AI services when benefits are salient and control is granular (Chakraborty et al., 2025; Morosan, 2025). Taken together, evidence supports a parsimonious pathway in which design levers act through psychological mechanisms (trust, perceived competence, perceived control, inspiration, rapport) to shape outcomes, conditional on context.

Contextual contingencies delimit portability across markets and settings. Customer orientation (outcome- vs process-focused) can shape preferences for human agents in airline service; technology readiness and digital literacy moderate perceived service quality across channels; and cultural differences shift

tolerance for automation, perceived privacy/identity threats, and the salience of hedonic versus utilitarian value (Chaouali et al., 2025; Mohammed & Ferraris, 2025; Rathjens et al., 2025; Vena-Oya et al., 2024). In Vietnam and Malaysia, field surveys and hybrid modelling of UTAUT2 constructs highlight warmth, speed, and competence as antecedents of trust, attitude, and continuance, yet show attenuation under technology anxiety and risk aversion (Foroughi et al., 2025; Pham et al., 2024). Rural and accessibility-centred contexts and luxury concierge services appear to benefit from human-in-the-loop designs that preserve relatedness and inclusion (Klaus, 2025; Marino-Romero et al., 2025; Pham, 2025a, 2025b). Such moderators argue against one-size-fits-all automation and favour orchestrated channel mixes, adaptive disclosure, and targeted handoffs.

Neighbouring strands provide scaffolding for integration. Reviews of chatbots adoption converge on performance expectancy, enjoyment, habit, information/interaction quality, and perceived control as robust determinants of continuance, with anthropomorphism and personalisation emerging as consistent design antecedents (Khrouf et al., 2025; Xu & Chen, 2025). Conceptual and bibliometric analyses map governance and workforce implications of generative AI and track emergent capabilities such as prompting strategies and multimodal agents (Altinay et al., 2025; Saleh, 2025). Research on explanation interfaces suggests that interactive, dialogue-based explanations can improve transparency and trust, whereas mismatched feature counts or modalities may miscalibrate expectations (Freeman & Beaver, 2018; Hernandez-Bocanegra & Ziegler, 2023; Zhang et al., 2022). What remains underdeveloped is a consolidated view that traces mechanisms across the journey, articulates boundary conditions, and translates synthesis into testable propositions and managerial guidance.

Using a protocolised bibliometric–systematic review (B-SLR) of Scopus (search window 2010–2025), the final eligible studies were published in 2018–2025. We include peer-reviewed journal articles that place conversational agents centrally within hotel, online travel agency (OTA), airline, or destination management organisation (DMO) use cases and that report user or firm outcomes and/or risk topics. We extract technology characteristics (rule-based, retrieval, LLM/generative; chat/voice/multimodal), design levers (speed, concision, style, anthropomorphism, disclosure/explanation, visual/emoji), outcomes (satisfaction, trust, adoption/continuance, efficiency, revenue proxies), and risks (privacy, fairness/bias, hallucination, disclosure), together with mediators and moderators (perceived control, failure severity, technology anxiety, digital literacy). This mixed evidence base (experiments, surveys, prototypes, and field analytics) allows triangulation of mechanisms and boundary conditions across settings.

This paper answers four linked questions. RQ1 examines how deployment patterns differ across customer-journey touchpoints. RQ2 tests how design choices relate to mechanisms and outcomes. RQ3 assesses the risks and governance issues that arise with generative conversational AI. RQ4 reviews how geography and collaboration shape the evidence base. These questions inform each other. Insights from RQ1 help explain the geographical and institutional patterns in RQ4, while RQ2 and RQ3 show how design mechanisms and governance limits work together to shape user experience and organisational results. The study seeks to close key gaps by offering an evidence-based account of mechanisms, outcomes, and boundary conditions in conversational AI for hospitality and tourism. It adds to the field by using a mechanism-in-context view that joins design, psychology, and contextual factors; by linking design levers to behavioural outcomes; and by turning the synthesis into practical principles for responsible use. The paper then outlines the review methods, reports descriptive and bibliometric results, discusses mechanisms tied to RQ1–RQ4, and ends with conclusions, limits, and future research needs.

2. Methodology

2.1. Scope and research questions

Following best practice for protocolised bibliometric–systematic reviews (B-SLR), we queried the Scopus database, selected for its comprehensive coverage of hospitality, tourism, and service management journals, on 1 August 2025 with a three-block Boolean covering conversational-AI terms, hospitality/travel domains, and customer-experience touchpoints. We restricted results to English-language journal articles within the 2010–2025 search window; all eligible studies were published 2018–2025 (no includable items pre-2018). The review addresses four questions (RQ1–RQ4): deployment patterns across touchpoints;

mechanisms and outcomes; risks/governance; and geography/collaboration, which collectively aim to link conversational design levers with behavioural and contextual outcomes in hospitality and tourism.

2.2. Search strategy and data source

The Scopus search applied a combined Boolean query for the three conceptual blocks, followed by sequential filters for year, language, source type, and document type. Table 1 outlines the filtering stages, record counts, and rationales. Scopus was selected as the primary data source due to its broader indexing of hospitality and tourism journals compared with Web of Science and ScienceDirect and its compatibility with bibliometric software such as VOSviewer. While Web of Science and ScienceDirect were not included, this decision was driven by the need for database consistency and deduplication control.

The inclusion of terms such as "service innovation" and "experience design" was intentional, as these concepts represent core conversational AI touchpoints related to recommendation, personalisation, and service recovery. They also capture innovation-orientated studies that deploy chatbots and virtual assistants within customer-experience or value-creation contexts.

2.3. Eligibility criteria (PICo), screening and study selection

Population: customers/service providers in hospitality & travel (hotels, OTAs, airlines, DMOs). Intervention: conversational AI (chatbots, virtual assistants, LLM/generative or multimodal agents) engaged in dialogic interaction.

Context: journey touchpoints, booking, concierge/guest service, recommendation/personalisation, service recovery/complaint handling. Inclusion: English, peer-reviewed journal articles (2010–2025 search window; eligible 2018–2025) that place conversational agents centrally and report user/firm outcomes (e.g. satisfaction, trust, adoption/continuance, efficiency, revenue proxies) and/or risk topics (privacy, bias/fairness, hallucination, disclosure).

Exclusion: non-conversational AI (e.g. computer vision, forecasting), non-hospitality domains without explicit transfer, purely algorithmic/theoretical papers lacking hospitality use cases, non-systematic reviews/notes/preprints, legacy IVR without modern conversational outcomes.

Screening and study selection: Records identified = 329; after limits (English, journal, article) = 115; title/abstract excluded = 42; full-text assessed = 73; full-text excluded = 2; included = 71 (Figure 1).

2.4. Data extraction, coding, and bibliometric procedures

A structured codebook captured bibliographic data; technology (rule-based/retrieval/LLM; chat/voice/multimodal); journey phase; design (lab, field, A/B, survey, qualitative, mixed); sample; outcomes; risks/ethics; mediators/moderators (e.g. anthropomorphism, disclosure, perceived control, failure severity); quality score; and keywords for bibliometrics. Dual extraction with cross-checks resolved discrepancies; a thesaurus harmonised constructs (e.g. personalisation/personalisation; LLM/GenAI/ChatGPT).

Table 1. Search pipeline and staged limits (scopus, TITLE-ABS-KEY).

Stage	Filter	Records remaining	Rationale
Baseline	Combined Boolean: (chatbot* OR "conversational agent*" OR "virtual assistant*" OR "large language model*" OR "LLM*" OR "generative AI") AND (hotel* OR hospitality OR tourism OR "online travel" OR "OTA" OR airline) AND ("service innovation" OR "experience design" OR recommendation OR personalization OR "service recovery" OR "customer service" OR "customer support" OR booking)	336	Anchor on dialogic AI within domain & touchpoints
Year limits	2010–2025	329	Exclude legacy/out-of-window items
Language	English only	327	Ensure comparability & appraisal consistency
Source type	Journals (SRCTYPE="j")	126	Focus on peer-reviewed journals
Document type	Article	115	Exclude reviews/editorials/notes
Eligibility (PICo)	Conversational agents at hotel/OTA/airline/DMO touchpoints with outcomes/risks	71	Final sample for synthesis

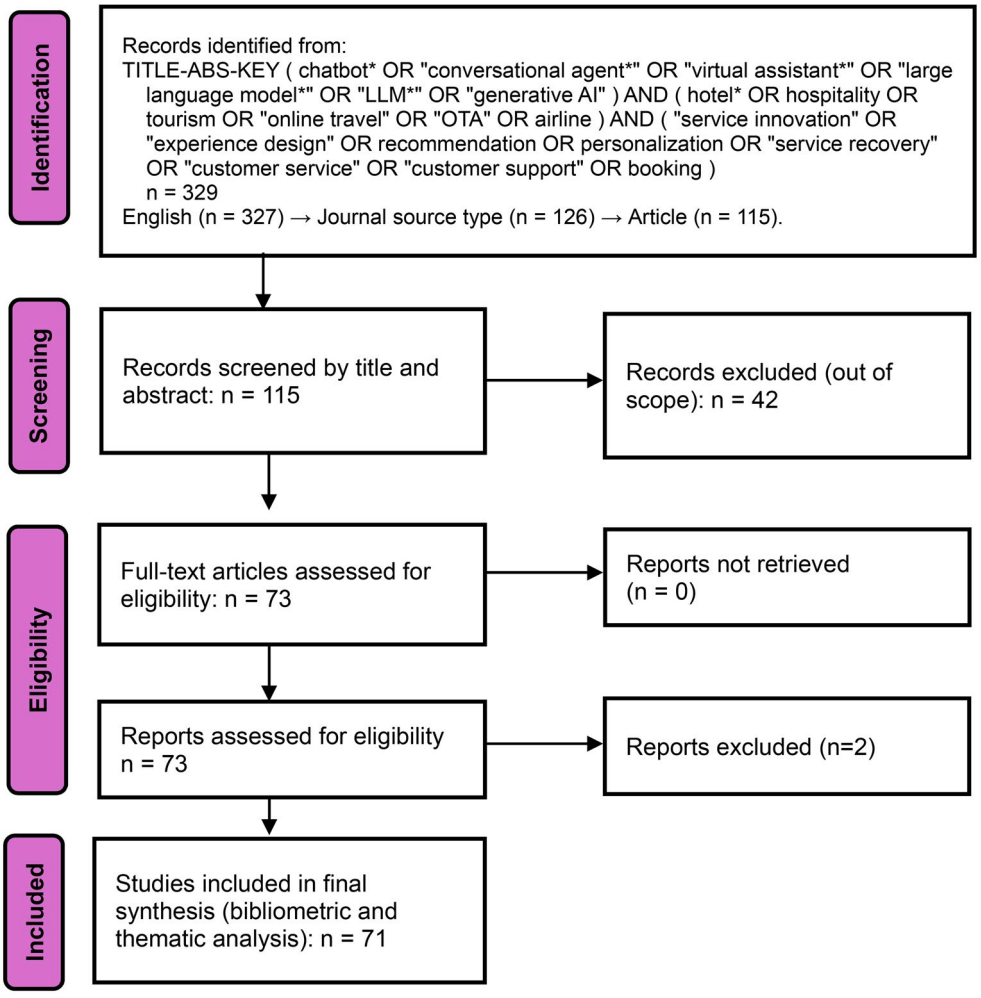


Figure 1. PRISMA 2020 flow diagram for study selection.

Using Biblioshiny 5.0 and VOSviewer (v1.6.20), we mapped keyword co-occurrence and Sankey plots. Unlike prior reviews, the current study includes detailed visualisations of these bibliometric relationships (Figures 2–4) and interprets each cluster to identify intellectual and geographic structures of the field. Clustering used resolution = 1.0 and minimum cluster size =5 with sensitivity checks ±0.2. Frontier terms (2023–2025) (LLM, RAG, multimodal, agentic/on-device) were flagged to characterise emergent themes.

2.5. Synthesis and theorising

The synthesis followed a mixed-method interpretive approach that combined bibliometric mapping with narrative analysis. Quantitative patterns were integrated with qualitative mechanisms by research cluster and journey touchpoint to enhance theoretical coherence. For RQ1, we developed a technology×touchpoint matrix (2010–2025) showing deployment evolution. For RQ2, we constructed an effect-direction heatmap linking design levers to mechanisms (speed/complexity, concision/social context, empathy/anthropomorphism, disclosure, perceived control). For RQ3–RQ4, we interpreted risk, governance, and collaboration networks, linking them to regional and institutional contexts. This synthesis supports theory-building by identifying mechanism-based pathways that explain adoption, trust, and satisfaction outcomes within hospitality and tourism conversational AI.

3. Results

3.1. Holistic analysis of the dataset

This section answers RQ4 by mapping the geographical, institutional, and intellectual profile of conversational AI research in hospitality and tourism. The final dataset includes 71 Scopus-indexed journal

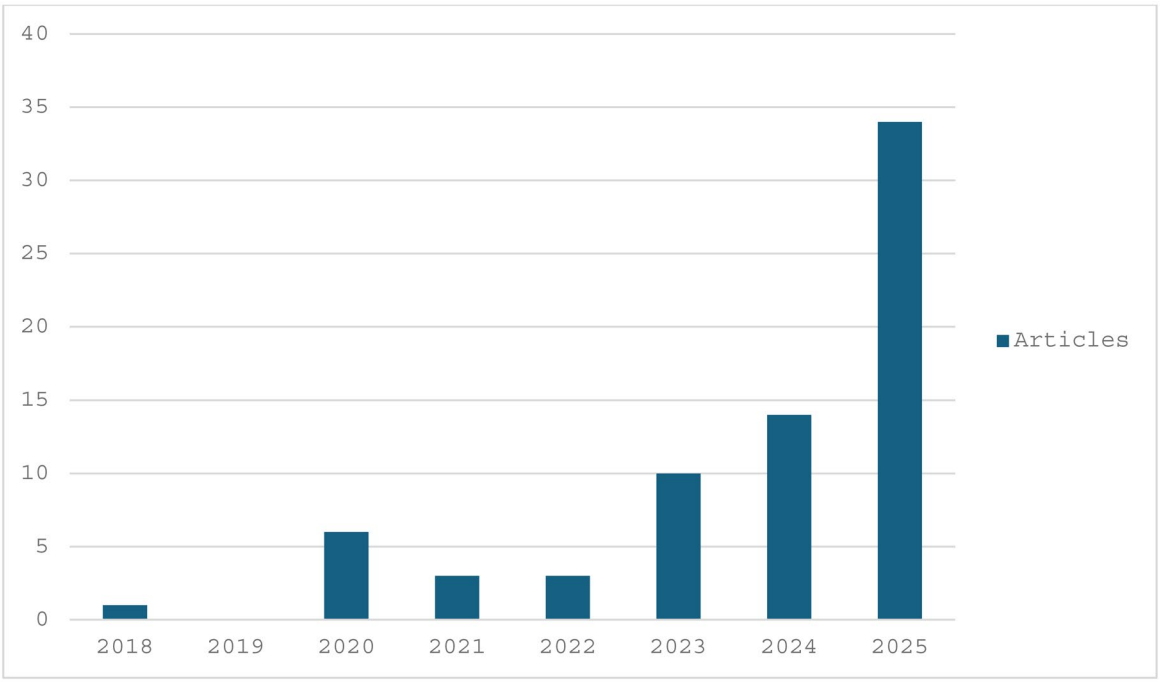


Figure 2. Annual scientific production.

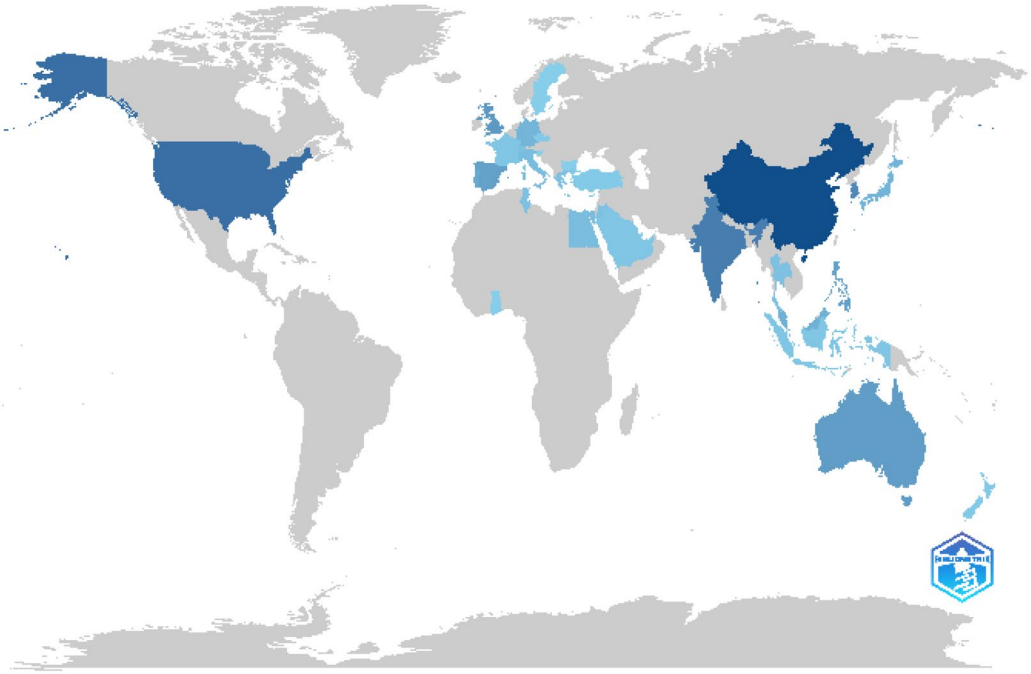


Figure 3. Country scientific production map (number of articles by corresponding author's country).

articles published from 2018 to 2025 (Figure 2; Table 2). Output is recent and grows fast, with an annual growth rate of 65.49%. Production rises sharply in 2024 and 2025, with 14 papers in 2024 and 34 in 2025, which together form almost half of the corpus. Although the average document age is only 1.3 years, each paper has been cited about 25 times, which signals quick uptake in the field. All items are peer-reviewed journal articles, which fits the B-SLR protocol and the PRISMA flow described in the methods. The 2024–2025 surge parallels the spread of large language models and shows how generative AI has shifted both research and industry debate. The rapid rise in citations suggests that conversational AI is not only a young topic but is becoming a central theme in hospitality innovation research.

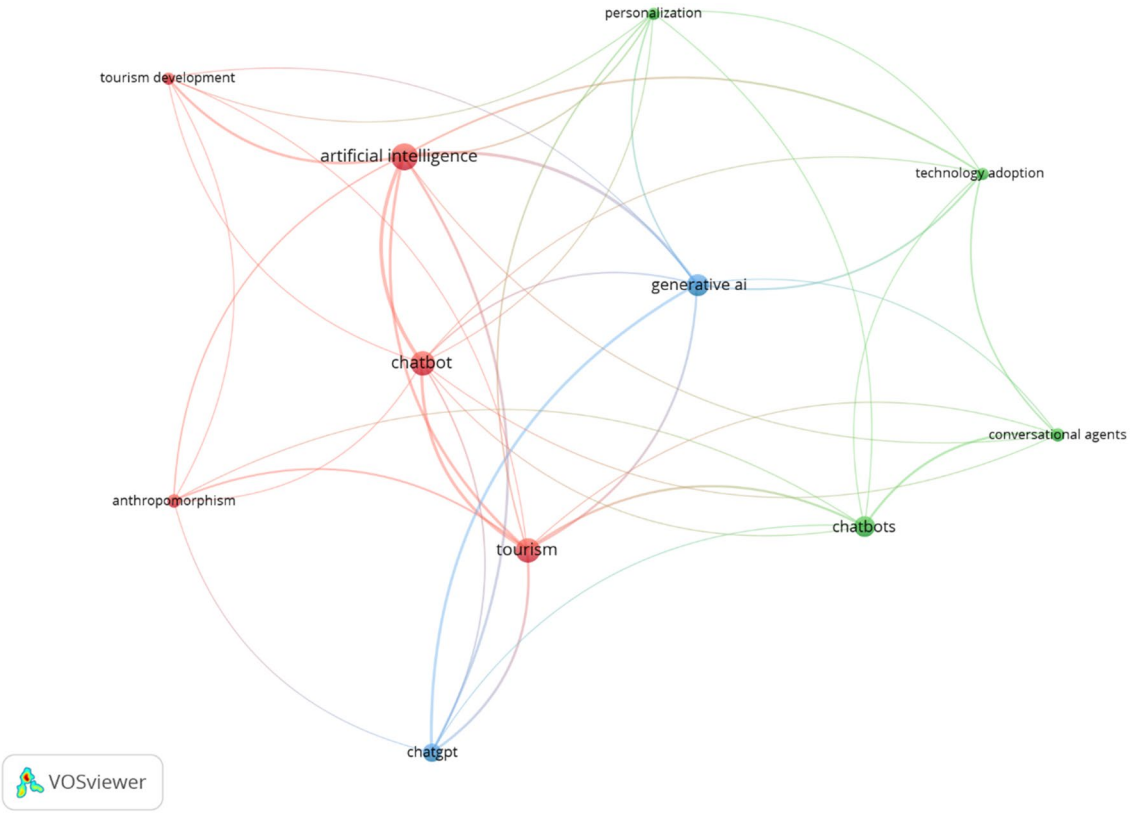


Figure 4. Keyword co-occurrence visualisation.

Table 2. Core dataset summary.

Description	Results
Main information about data	
Timespan	2018:2025
Sources (Journals)	46
Documents	71
Annual growth rate %	65.49
Document average age	1.3
Average citations per doc	24.56
References	627
Document contents	
Keywords plus (ID)	219
Author's keywords (DE)	280
Authors	
Authors	295
Authors of single-authored docs	0
Authors collaboration	
Single-authored docs	0
Co-authors per doc	7.17
International co-authorships %	33.8
Document types	
article	71

Authorship patterns also show a collaborative field (Table 2). None of the 71 papers are single-authored. Instead, the corpus includes 295 distinct authors, or about seven authors per paper, and one third of the papers involve international teams. This level of collaboration points to a maturing and interdisciplinary area that draws on marketing, service operations, computer science, and tourism management.

3.2. Source and disciplinary anchoring

Disciplinary anchoring sits mainly in hospitality and tourism journals, with strong input from service and consumer-behaviour outlets. The most active sources include the Journal of Hospitality and Tourism

Technology, the International Journal of Hospitality Management, and the International Journal of Contemporary Hospitality Management. These journals account for a large share of the output in the dataset (Table 3).

This concentration shows that conversational AI has moved from a niche technology topic to a recognised part of core hospitality and tourism research. Many of these journals now publish studies that link AI design, service recovery, and customer-journey models. This trend signals growing alignment between service-innovation research and human–AI interaction theory.

3.3. Institutional and geographic patterns

Institutionally, the field is led by Asia–Pacific universities, with Kyung Hee University contributing 14 papers, followed by Polytechnic University of the Philippines (7), University of Canberra and a School of Management entry (each 6). This regional dominance underscores how Asia–Pacific scholars are driving empirical experimentation and cross-disciplinary work in conversational AI, while European and North American institutions contribute more conceptual and governance-focused research (Table 4).

Geographically, scientific output is concentrated in China (34 papers), the United States (25), India (21), South Korea (18), the United Kingdom (14), Australia (13), the Philippines (12), Spain (12), and Portugal (10) (Table 5; Figure 3). Africa and Latin America are almost absent from the country production map. This imbalance suggests that current insights lean toward digitally advanced markets and that future work should include more regions to improve inclusivity and cross-regional validity.

3.4. Intellectual and topical structure

To answer RQ2, this section maps the conceptual and intellectual structure of conversational AI research in hospitality and tourism through a keyword co-occurrence analysis using VOSviewer. The network in Figure 4 shows three main thematic clusters that form the field's core. The first cluster covers design and user-experience work. These studies show how emotional engagement, trust, and perceived warmth shape customer responses and satisfaction. They draw on social-presence theory, parasocial interaction, and expectancy-violation ideas to explain how human-like cues influence service quality. The second cluster covers behavioural and adoption models such as TAM and UTAUT2. These papers highlight performance expectancy, enjoyment, and perceived control as key drivers of adoption and continued use in AI-enabled service settings. The third cluster reflects the rise of large-language-model systems and brings

Table 3. Most productive sources (top journals and article counts).

Sources	Articles
Journal of hospitality and tourism technology	5
International journal of contemporary hospitality management	4
International journal of hospitality management	4
Geojournal of tourism and geosites	3
Journal of hospitality and tourism insights	3
Journal of retailing and consumer services	3
Journal of travel research	3
Asia pacific journal of tourism research	2
Current issues in tourism	2

Table 4. Leading affiliations by article count.

Affiliation	Articles
Kyung hee university	14
Polytechnic university of the philippines	7
School of management	6
University of canberra	6
Chongqing university	5
Rosen college of hospitality management	5
Hainan university	4
Jss academy of technical education	4
Universidad de extremadura	4

Table 5. Most productive countries/regions.

Region	Freq
China	34
Usa	25
India	21
South korea	18
Uk	14
Australia	13
Philippines	12
Spain	12
Portugal	10

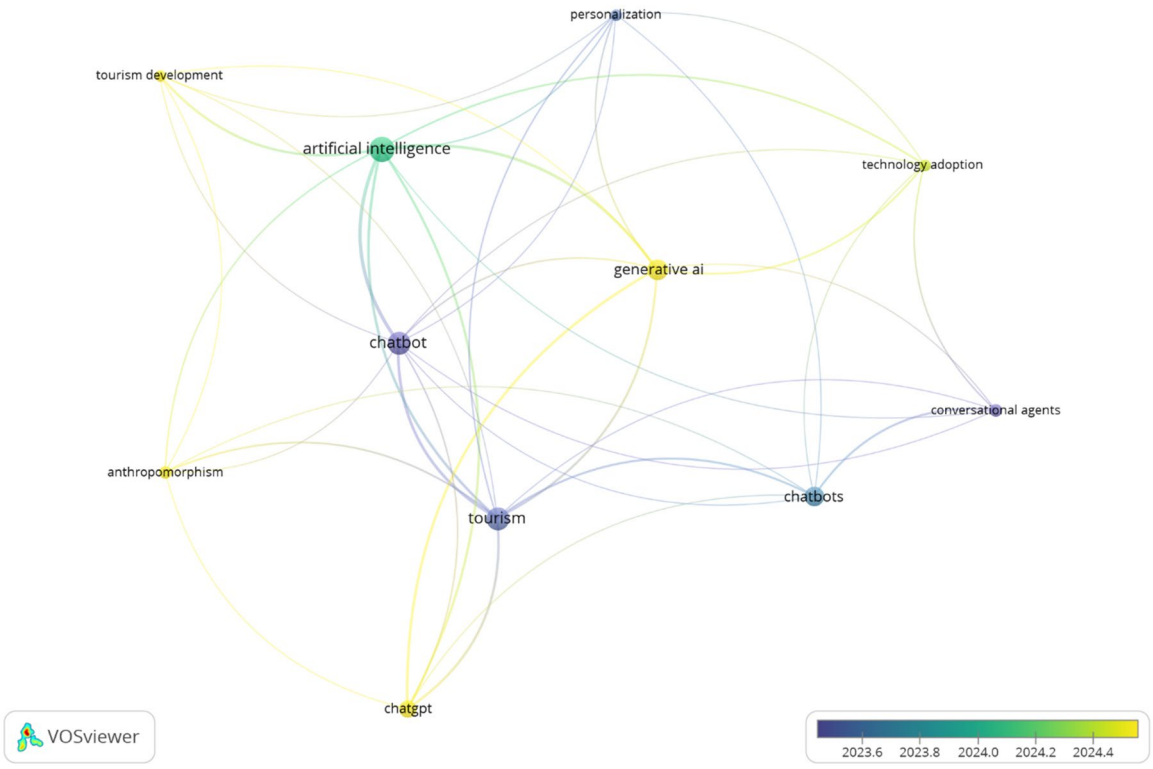


Figure 5. Overlay visualisation.

in issues linked to privacy, ethics, and responsible deployment. This cluster marks a shift from simple automation to deeper discussions of interpretability, transparency, and fairness.

The overlay visualisation in Figure 5 shows how the field has changed from 2018 to 2025. Early work from 2018 to 2021, shown in blue, focused on basic chatbots studies, anthropomorphism, and tourism development. These papers marked the first wave of conceptual testing. Recent work from 2023 to 2025, shown in yellow, highlights terms such as "generative AI," "ChatGPT," and "personalisation." This shift signals the move into the LLM era and shows rising interest in accuracy, empathy calibration, transparency, and fairness. The colour gradient in the map illustrates the field's growth from descriptive, technology-centred studies to more analytical work that examines human–AI interaction quality and governance.

The density map in Figure 6 highlights areas of strong thematic activity and confirms the central concepts in the field. These dense zones bring together three linked domains: technological innovation, customer-experience design, and ethical AI governance. The strong presence of "ChatGPT" and "LLM" shows how quickly generative AI tools have entered research and industry practice. This shift underscores a deeper theoretical move that connects psychological mechanisms such as trust, empathy, and control with system-level concerns such as privacy, explainability, and authenticity.

The three-field Sankey plot in Figure 7 shows how publication outlets, country affiliations, and author keywords connect to one another. Leading hospitality journals such as IJHM, IJCHM, JHTT, JTR, and JHTI

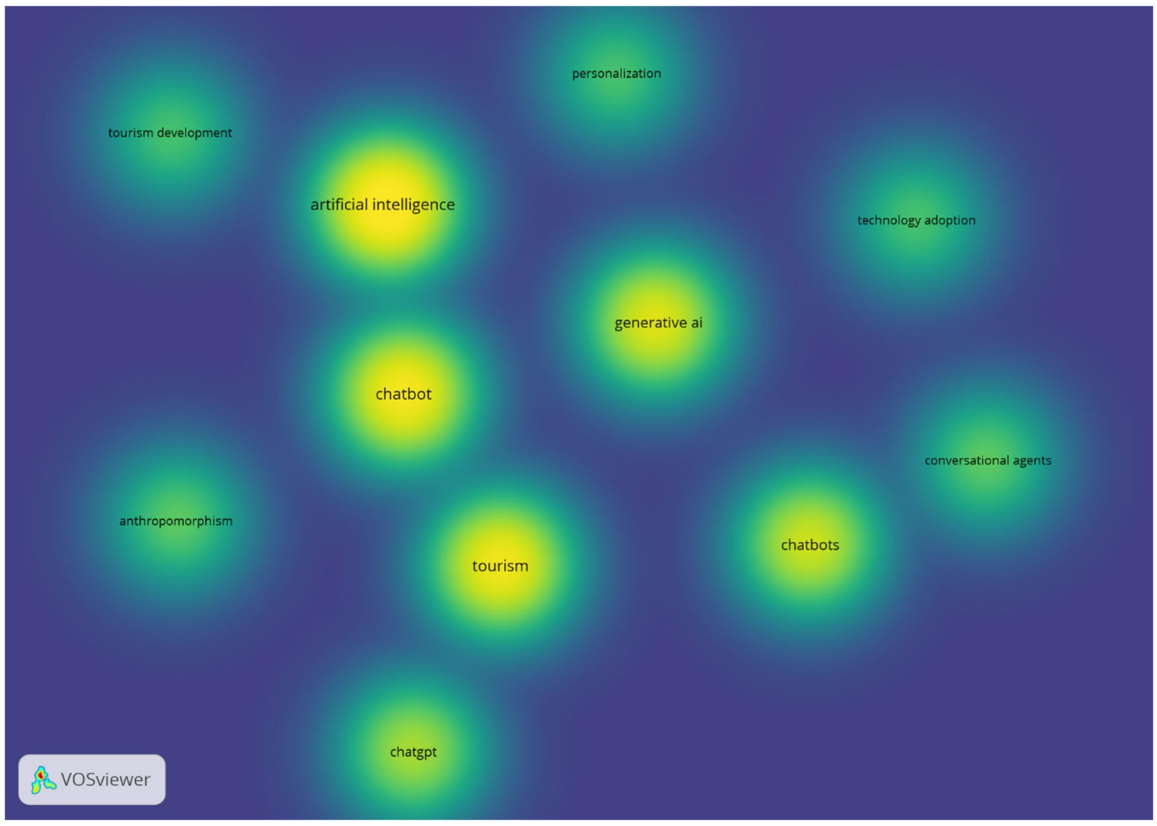


Figure 6. Density map.

link strongly to authors based in China, the United States, South Korea, India, and Australia. These countries then connect to major themes such as "chatbot," "generative AI," "anthropomorphism," and "personalization." The pattern shows that Asia–Pacific and Anglophone countries drive much of the field's empirical and theoretical work on conversational AI in hospitality.

Across all visualisations, the evidence shows that research on conversational AI in hospitality and tourism has moved beyond descriptive mapping and now builds more integrated and theory-led frameworks. Three main streams shape the field: design and user-experience mechanisms tied to social cognition and anthropomorphism, behavioural adoption models that explain continuance and trust, and governance and ethics work responding to the rise of LLMs. Together, these streams answer RQ2 by showing that the field's core focus lies in explaining how design features of conversational AI activate psychological mechanisms and support responsible service experiences.

4. Discussion

This discussion builds a theory-led narrative that links technological patterns with psychological and managerial mechanisms. The aim is to explain how conversational AI shapes customer experience across hospitality and tourism touchpoints. Following B-SLR guidance on transparent synthesis (Marzi et al., 2025) and recent chat-AI reviews (Prasanna et al., 2025; Xu & Chen, 2025), the section interprets the evidence through key frameworks such as social presence theory, expectancy-violation theory, and technology adoption models. Design levers such as speed, concision, empathic style, anthropomorphism, disclosure, visual cues, and privacy controls act as stimuli. These stimuli trigger mechanisms linked to trust, perceived competence, perceived control, rapport, and emotional comfort. These mechanisms then shape outcomes such as satisfaction, loyalty, and continued use. This approach helps explain variation across studies by accounting for moderators such as task complexity, user traits, failure severity, and cultural or digital literacy levels.

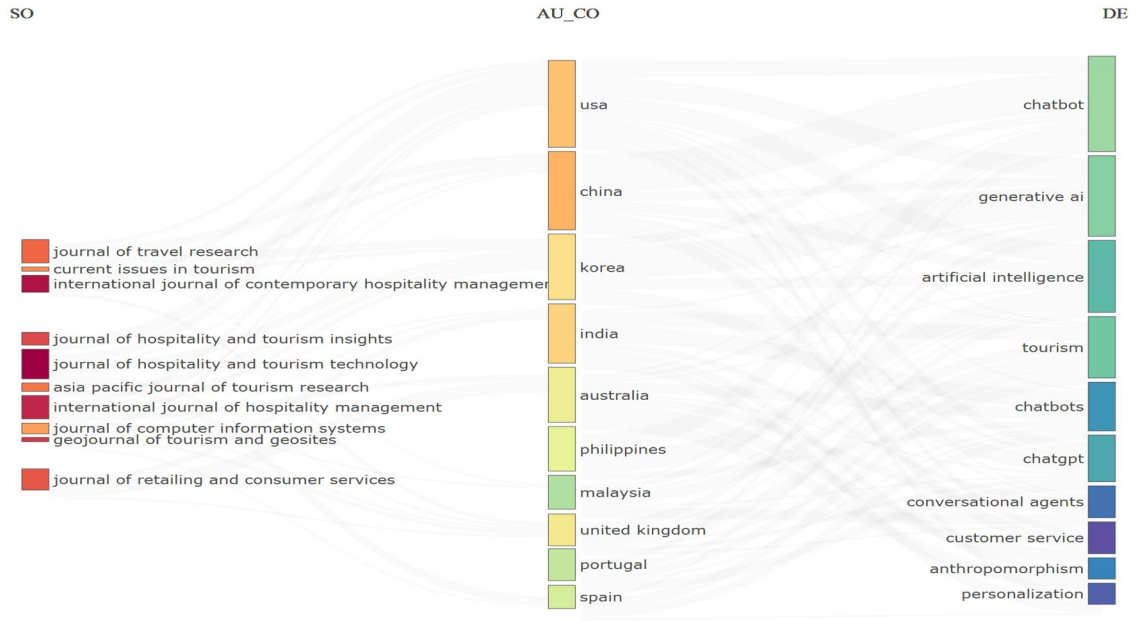


Figure 7. Three-field Sankey plot (Sources → Countries → Author Keywords).

4.1. Deployment patterns across the journey (RQ1)

Early deployments between 2018 and 2021 relied on rule-based or simple NLP chatbots designed for FAQs and destination information (Alotaibi, 2020; Gunawan et al., 2020; Kasinathan et al., 2020). These tools served as early proofs of concept but lacked contextual understanding and emotional depth. Over time, systems evolved toward task-orientated and machine-learning models that supported itineraries and recommendations (Acharya et al., 2020; Sperlí, 2021). Comparative work showed that human live chat remained the benchmark for trust, which pushed designers to keep emotional alignment in automated services (Kim et al., 2025a, 2025b; Park et al., 2025; Yu et al., 2025).

Since 2023, the rise of large language models has reshaped applications across the sector. LLM-based assistants offer stronger information quality, more convincing empathy, and deeper personalisation. They also introduce risks linked to hallucination and privacy. Experiments show that timely, concise, and socially adaptive LLM responses improve decision comfort and increase adoption of recommendations (Lei et al., 2021; McLean et al., 2020; Um et al., 2020). Destination systems that blend LLMs with retrieval-augmented generation produce high-quality answers under expert review (Cruz et al., 2025). In luxury settings, human-in-the-loop designs remain important to preserve warmth and trust (Klaus, 2025). These patterns indicate a division of labour: LLM chat works well for inspiration and planning, while hybrid designs are needed for high-stakes or emotionally charged situations.

4.2. Outcomes and cross-study mechanisms (RQ2)

Results across the corpus point to a shared mechanism. Design levers activate cognitive and emotional responses, and these responses shape behavioural intentions and loyalty. Concise messages improve decision comfort, especially when social distance is high, which supports the idea of cognitive fluency (Yu et al., 2025).

Warm and human-like styles strengthen engagement and hedonic value, in line with social-presence and parasocial theories (Bhattacharjee et al., 2025). Anthropomorphic cues increase trust and brand attachment when used carefully, but they can reduce credibility if perceived as manipulative (Kumar, 2025). Studies that use TAM and UTAUT2 show that performance expectancy, enjoyment, and habit remain central mediators of continued use (Foroughi et al., 2025; Khrouf et al., 2025; Pham et al., 2024; Romero-Charneco et al., 2025).

In service recovery, empathy alignment between chatbots and human agents increases forgiveness and retention. Symbolic gestures such as apologies and acknowledgements work best when they appear before factual remedies. This highlights the importance of emotional sequencing (Wang et al., 2024; Zaki & Al-Romeedy, 2024). Disclosure also matters. Early, blunt AI identification can weaken empathic benefit. Embedded or contextual disclosure protects authenticity and fairness (Fan et al., 2024). These findings show that successful conversational AI depends on a balance between efficient interaction and emotional resonance.

4.3. Risks, ethics, and governance (RQ3)

The LLM era brings new ethical and operational risks. Hallucination and opaque reasoning weaken trust, and perceived accuracy has become a basic requirement for adoption. Privacy concerns continue to shape user decisions, and willingness to share data or pay for personalisation depends on perceived control and fairness (Chakraborty et al., 2025; Morosan, 2025). Cross-cultural studies show that digital literacy and cultural norms influence how users judge automation and ethical risk. This underscores the need for governance models that fit local conditions (Mohammed & Ferraris, 2025; Seyfi et al., 2025).

Interface-level evidence shows that dense or overly complex explanations can reduce trust. This supports calls for explainable AI and context-appropriate transparency (Hernandez-Bocanegra & Ziegler, 2023; Zhang et al., 2022). Conceptual studies propose privacy-by-design, traceable disclosure, and labels for synthetic content as ways to protect accountability in generative systems (Carvalho & Ivanov, 2024; Mladenović et al., 2024).

4.4. Geography, institutions, and collaboration (RQ4)

Geographical and institutional patterns show that Asia–Pacific and Anglophone countries dominate conversational AI research. China, the United States, South Korea, and Australia serve as key nodes, reflecting both technological capacity and early adoption. Countries such as the Philippines and Portugal are becoming active contributors, often through applied rather than theory-heavy research. Differences in national digital readiness and cultural attitudes explain the mixed findings in cross-country adoption studies (Mohammed & Ferraris, 2025; Vena-Oya et al., 2024).

The limited presence of Africa and Latin America reveals an ongoing geographical imbalance. This limits the field's ability to generalise behavioural mechanisms across diverse cultural and economic contexts. Future hospitality AI theory must broaden its scope beyond high-resource environments to build inclusive and globally relevant knowledge.

4.5. Theoretical implications

Synthesising the evidence, this review advances a mechanism-in-context model of conversational AI in hospitality and tourism. Design levers (speed, concision, warmth, anthropomorphism, disclosure, visual cues, privacy, and human handoff) are conceptualised as independent variables influencing psychological mechanisms (trust, competence, perceived control, rapport, and inspiration) that predict behavioural outcomes (adoption, satisfaction, recovery effectiveness, loyalty, and data-disclosure willingness). This relational model integrates cognitive (expectancy-violation), affective (social presence), and behavioural (adoption) theories into a unified explanatory framework. Contextual moderators (including task complexity, failure severity, user traits, and culture) define boundary conditions that explain heterogeneous effects across studies. Table 6 summarises these mappings.

To formalise this theoretical step, the review sets out five testable propositions that link design features to predicted mechanisms and outcomes.

1. P1 (Speed × Complexity): Faster responses raise satisfaction until a cognitive limit is reached, after which extreme speed reduces perceived care and trust.
2. P2 (Concision × Social Context): Short and context-aware messages improve decision comfort when social distance is high.

Table 6. Evidence of principal mapping.

Design principle	Mechanism(s)	Design/method	Touchpoint	Exemplar evidence
Prioritize speed with complexity guardrails	Trust; competence; expectancy-violation down	Experiments	Recommendation/ Planning	Kim et al. (2025a, 2025b)
Match recommendation length to social context (concise generally helps; verbose can win when social distance is high)	Decision comfort; attitudes	Experiments	Recommendation/ Concierge	Yu et al. (2025)
Align empathic tone across bot–human during recovery	Empathy → retention	Survey + Lab + Field (Mixed)	Recovery	Fan et al. (2024)
Sequence symbolic → informational acts in recovery	Forgiveness; continuous trust	Survey (moderated mediation) + Experiments	Recovery	Wang et al. (2024); Zaki and Al-Romeedy (2024)
Use visual menus/emoji to enhance responsiveness/ playfulness	Perceived responsiveness; social playfulness	Experiments	Concierge/ Recommendation	Park et al. (2025)
Provide calibrated explanations (why/how)	Transparency; calibrated trust	User studies/SEM (HCI)	Recommendation (XAI)	Hernandez-Bocanegra and Ziegler (2023; Zhang et al. (2022)
Implement privacy-by-design and consent granularity	Disclosure willingness; continuance	Survey + LPA; Longitudinal Survey	Personalization/Service	Chakraborty et al. (2025; Morosan (2025)
Deploy anthropomorphism with moderation	Positive affect; brand love; failure-tolerance (low severity)	Survey/SEM; Scoping review	OTA CS/Recovery (low-severity)	Kumar (2025); Majeed et al. (2024)
Maintain accuracy & error-salience controls	Trust; visit intention	Multi-study Experiments; Prototype (RAG)	Planning/Hotel selection	Cruz et al. (2025); Kim et al. (2025a, 2025b)
Use hybrid handoff for high-stakes episodes	Satisfaction; retention	Cross-sectional survey (benchmark human chat); Comparative survey (PLS-SEM)	CS/Recovery/Premium concierge	Lei et al. (2021; McLean et al. (2020)

3. P3 (Disclosure Timing): Embedded disclosure protects empathy and retention, in line with expectancy-violation theory.
4. P4 (Symbolic → Informational Sequencing): An apology or acknowledgement before an explanation increases forgiveness, as predicted by affect-based trust models.
5. P5 (Privacy-by-Design): Federated processing and granular consent tools support long-term adoption among privacy-sensitive users.

5. Conclusion

This review builds a theory-led understanding of how conversational AI reshapes hospitality and tourism services by combining bibliometric mapping with a mechanisms-based synthesis. It shows that design levers such as speed, concision, empathic tone, anthropomorphism, disclosure, visual cues, privacy features, and hybrid human handoff operate through psychological mechanisms linked to trust, perceived competence, perceived control, inspiration, and rapport. These mechanisms, in turn, predict outcomes such as adoption, continued use, satisfaction, loyalty, recovery success, and willingness to share data. Together, they form a coherent mechanism-in-context framework.

The review moves past descriptive summaries and brings theory to the centre of AI-in-tourism research. It shows how design–mechanism–outcome relationships vary by task complexity, user traits, and cultural or digital literacy. It also sets out five testable propositions that link conversational design elements with behavioural and ethical outcomes. This theoretical integration sets the review apart from earlier work by naming clear pathways drawn from social presence theory, expectancy-violation theory, and cognitive trust models.

For managers, the findings translate into practical design and governance guidance. Organisations should match conversational AI capabilities with specific customer-journey stages, adjust response speed and message length to the task and social setting, and time empathy and disclosure carefully in human–AI exchanges. Multimodal tools such as emojis and visual menus can increase perceived warmth and responsiveness. At the same time, transparent explanations and privacy-by-design safeguards protect trust and support regulatory compliance.

6. Limitations and future research

While this review provides theoretical and practical insights, certain limitations should be acknowledged to guide interpretation and future work. First, despite rigorous construct harmonisation and inter-rater reliability checks, heterogeneity in study design and measurement remains a challenge, limiting meta-analytic generalisation. Second, some domains such as upselling, workforce adaptation, and ethical governance are under-represented and rely mainly on exploratory or managerial studies. Third, the reliance on Scopus-indexed, English-language journals (while ensuring data quality) excludes potentially relevant regional or non-English sources, particularly from Africa and Latin America, which constrains geographical representativeness.

We therefore prioritise five future research agendas: (1) field A/B and natural experiments in live OTAs, hotels, and airlines to validate speed–complexity trade-offs, disclosure strategies, and explanation granularity under operational constraints; (2) privacy-preserving personalisation using latent-profile-informed consent mechanisms and transparent control dashboards; (3) examination of human–AI collaboration and recovery triads to test empathy congruence, handoff timing, and symbolic → informational sequencing; and (4) evaluation of multimodal and accessibility-orientated designs for low-resource and disability-support contexts. Future studies should also integrate theoretical triangulation (linking psychological, sociotechnical, and ethical perspectives) to build cumulative knowledge that connects design science, behavioural theory, and responsible AI governance.

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Data availability statement

The data that support the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

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